SCENARIO AND PROPOSAL · VERIFIED SLOWDOWN

AI 2040: Plan A

The project sketches a US–China agreement that slows the frontier while verification, safety research, and shared institutions mature, then permits further progress under stronger controls.

Background and provenance

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

The AI Futures Project presents a desirable alternative to the loss-of-control and power-concentration outcomes explored in its earlier AI 2027 scenario. AI 2040: Plan A is explicitly a recommendation told through a detailed future scenario, not the team's prediction of what governments will do. Its authors use the story to test whether a slower, more transparent international path could preserve both safety and wider access to AI's benefits.

PEOPLE AND ORGANISATIONS

The six named authors are Thomas Larsen, Romeo Dean, Brendan Halstead, Eli Lifland, Ryan Greenblatt, and Daniel Kokotajlo. The publisher is the AI Futures Project, which describes itself as a research nonprofit forecasting advanced AI and recommending ways to navigate it. Its About page credits Lightcone Infrastructure with helping build the website. Neither the scenario nor its verification supplement is an adopted government or lab policy.

KEY DATES

The AI Futures Project announced AI 2040: Plan A on 9 July 2026. It said the team had spent roughly the preceding year developing the scenario. The website and its supplements continue to change, and the site's About page records later edits. Dates inside the 2029–2040 story are imagined policy milestones, not dates when the document was written or published.

EARLIER FOUNDATIONS

The earlier AI 2027 project supplied the forecast of possible catastrophe or concentrated power to which this project responds. AI 2040: Plan A is the team's proposed alternative, with a separate Verification Plan supplement that spells out possible checks on compute, facilities, and research. The supplement elaborates the 2026 proposal; it is not a much older document repackaged under a new title.

Sources: AI 2040: Plan A ↗ Project and changelog ↗ Release announcement ↗

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ORGANISATION / AFFILIATION	AI Futures Project
ORIGINAL DOCUMENT	**AI 2040: Plan A ↗** **Official verification supplement ↗**

PURPOSE

The core motivation is preventing loss of control and catastrophic outcomes from a superintelligence race. The scenario also tries to avert irreversible concentration of power. Economic disruption matters in the broader vision but is not the main trigger for its compute pause.

WHAT IS PACED

Large training runs and frontier capability growth first, then model development and release inside verified research facilities. The plan allows controlled inference and later bounded capability advances, rather than demanding a permanent stop to AI progress.

WHEN AND FOR HOW LONG

Preparatory verification work begins as soon as possible. The illustrated scenario has a US–China deal and temporary training pause in 2029, controlled human-range progress around 2030–35, another pause near top-human-expert capability, and a possible unpause by 2040. These are scenario dates, not a fixed policy timetable.

HOW PACING WORKS

Mutual compute declarations and inference-only retrofits constrain training during the first pause. Later, transparent R&D sites, safety cases, inspected training, and joint decisions govern capability advances and model release.

VERIFICATION METHODS

The official supplement proposes chip counts and supply-chain accounting, bounding undeclared compute, removal of backend training links, passive network taps, reproducible workload packets with sampled recomputation, weight security, and inspectors at R&D facilities. Several elements are research agendas, not mature deployed systems.

WHO RUNS IT

The story centers on a reciprocal US–China arrangement backed by national authorities, international verification, facility inspectors, and lab safety cases. Governance becomes more formal as the arrangement progresses.

LIMITATIONS

The verification supplement calls its design a current best guess and lists substantial engineering work. Hidden compute, hardware tampering, efficiency gains, incomplete transparency, and the difficulty of political trust could undermine the timetable.

Mapped verification methods

11 mechanisms in the atlas map to this text. The labels indicate the strength of each match, not whether the method works.

Chip production and transfer ledger
Core

Interconnect bandwidth cap
Core

Network tap plus sampled recomputation
Core

Physical chip inventory inspection
Core

Weight custody and egress monitoring
Core

Cloud workload metering
Partial match

Facility power and cooling reconciliation
Partial match

Independent predeployment capability evaluation
Partial match

Model and checkpoint provenance registry
Partial match

Training transcript and checkpoint replay
Partial match

Trusted execution and remote attestation
Partial match

Explore the comparison

See all eight proposals by mechanism →

This is an analytical summary of the linked proposal. Examples and scenario dates are identified as such; see the original document for the authors' full arguments.